

SENATE No. 2884

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

SENATE, January 8, 2026.

The committee on Mental Health, Substance Use and Recovery to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 1385) of Joanne M. Comerford for legislation to expand loan repayment assistance for primary care physicians, report the accompanying bill (Senate, No. 2884).

For the committee,
Robyn K. Kennedy

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An Act expanding loan repayment assistance for primary care physicians working in integrated primary and behavioral health care settings.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. Chapter 6A of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after
2 section 16GG the following section:-

3 Section 16HH. There shall be established and set up on the books of the commonwealth a
4 separate fund to be known as the integrating behavioral health and primary care workforce trust
5 fund to which shall be credited any appropriations, bond proceeds or other monies authorized by
6 the general court and specifically designated to be credited thereto, and additional funds,
7 including federal grants or loans or private donations. Any balance in the fund at the close of a
8 fiscal year shall be available for expenditure in subsequent fiscal years and shall not revert to the
9 General Fund.

10 Amounts credited to the fund shall be expended for the purposes of expanding primary
11 care capacity in geographically underserved communities as determined by the secretary of
12 health and human services in consultation with the health policy commission.

The secretary of health and human services shall administer funds from the trust fund through grants to primary care physicians, including, but not be limited to, family physicians, internal medicine physicians, pediatricians, obstetricians and gynecologists; provided that, the secretary shall prioritize the recruitment and retention of a culturally, ethnically and linguistically diverse workforce; provided further, that, to be eligible for such grants, primary care physicians shall:

(a) work in a practice setting: (1) with a significant public payor patient population as determined by the secretary; and (2) that integrates primary and behavioral health care;

(b) have outstanding educational debt;

(c) not participate in any other Massachusetts loan repayment program; and

(d) be required to enter into a contract with the commonwealth for not less than 4 years; and provided further, that the amounts of assistance per individual shall be pro-rated for individuals working on a part-time basis.

The executive office of health and human services shall promulgate regulations for the administration of the fund, which shall include the grant application process, eligible uses of grant funds and penalties and repayment procedures if a participating individual fails to comply with the program requirements; provided, however, that not less than 45 days prior to the obligation of funds, the executive office shall submit a comprehensive program plan to the executive office for administration and finance, the house and senate committees on ways and means, the joint committee on mental health, substance use and recovery, the joint committee on public health, the joint committee on labor and workforce development and the joint committee on health care financing.

35 Not later than 6 months from the distribution of the first grant from the fund and by
36 January 1 annually thereafter, the secretary of health and human services shall file a report with
37 the clerks of the senate and the house of representatives, the joint committee on mental health,
38 substance use and recovery, the joint committee on public health, the joint committee on labor
39 and workforce development and the house and senate committees on ways and means detailing:
40 (i) the number of applications received; (ii) the number of grants awarded; (iii) the dollar amount
41 per grant; and (iv) any additional information deemed relevant by the secretary.